(a *principal*) is trying to do something (an *action*) to something (a *resource*) —but only if the right *conditions* are met. Together, these elements provide a common, widely applicable framework for thinking about and discussing access decisions. PARC offers a structured way to analyze policies and authorization requests, making them easier to analyze, test, and manage.

The *principal* is the entity that makes the request. Examples of principals include a person, a service account, or an IoT device. Principals often have attributes that can be referenced in a policy, such as their department, clearance level, role, or group membership.

The *action* refers to the operation that the principal wants to perform. Common actions include `read`, `write`, `update`, and `delete`. They are often specific to the application or service that executes the request. For instance, a photo-sharing application might include actions like `ShareWithFriend`, `ShareWithGroup`, or `ApplyPhotoFilter`. In APIs, actions typically represent the verbs associated with the API endpoints.

The *resource* is the object or entity on which the action is performed. Examples include generic resources like a database row or document, but they can also include application-specific objects such as an `account`, `invoice`, or `photo`. Resources are often organized hierarchically, with these groups also qualifying as resources. For instance, an action might apply to all the photos in a particular folder. Like principals, resources can have attributes—such as `owner`, `classification`, or `status`—which can be referenced in the policy. Again, these attributes are usually application-specific.

The *condition* is the context in which access is permitted or denied. Conditions might include factors such as time, location, device trust, risk score, or workload identity. *Workload identity* refers to the identity of the service or process making the request on behalf of the principal. For example, an API policy might require that the calling service's identity include a tag like `env=production` or that it runs in a secure enclave. Conditions are typically the most dynamic aspect of the PARC model and can depend on attributes of the principal, the resource, or the environment—or combinations of these elements.